industries and urging the audience to take shares in SSNCo.[93] As a result, apart from Abraham Pandithar, the landlord and Tamil scholar K.S. Srinivasa Pillai and one B.S. Mani Aiyar took forty-five shares.[94] Pandithurai Thevar had made similar attempts to raise capital at Nagapattinam, a port of some standing, while on his way to Thanjavur.[95] However, as the bearer of 'a hollow crown', he had to be circumspect in openly taking up the nationalist cause, and therefore cloaked his propaganda in the language of constructive enterprise. At the Hindu High School, Triplicane in Madras City on 3 August, Pandithurai Thevar chose the innocuous topic of 'Altruism' (*parobakaram*). Probably speaking in a high literary register, he gently rebuked traditional forms of philanthropy such as building free pilgrim houses and endowing temples. He argued, instead, for the setting up of schools, industries and trading companies. Only such constructive activities would further the material and moral well-being of the nation. Lest the audience miss the point, he urged the audience to invest in SSNCo and assured them that the entire coastal trade of India would soon be in the company's hands.[96]

Not all efforts bore fruit. In early August 1907, the zamindar of Ettayapuram came to Tuticorin. Though he was there to settle some legal dispute, it was said that he was also considering taking shares in SSNCo. He was expected to invest after taking a look at the steamers and making first-hand inquiries about the company's management.[97] The zamindar was even taken in a procession by the company, but in the event, he did not loosen his purse strings—his loyalist pedigree may have influenced his decision.[98]

In September 1907, the minor zamindar of Ramnad—evidently at the instance of Pandithurai Thevar—arrived in Tuticorin to a festive welcome with buntings and festoons. The hope was that he would subscribe capital after inspecting the Swadeshi steamer, though, as it turned out, his estate was in deep debt, and he could hardly afford to do so.[99]

Many others joined the canvassing campaign fired by Swadeshi ideals. M.R. Kandaswami Kavirayar, a leading scholar associated with the Madurai